

their needs have changed. That is the reason why Microsoft has changed. And it's not just Microsoft that has changed. You can see a lot of change happening across the board even in the open source community. In recent times, we have seen tremendous opportunities where we can partner with open source and vice versa. There are a huge number of developers who use technologies varying from Dot Net and Java to PHP. So, what Microsoft has done is focus on the fact that we don't want to tell PHP developers to give away their expertise in PHP and start developing on Dot Net. We want them to continue with PHP and leverage their expertise in PHP. What we ensure now is to work with the PHP community so that PHP runs as well on our platform (Windows) as it does on any other. So that's the kind of partnership that we are looking at driving.

Microsoft is putting in humongous efforts within the company towards driving strategic partnerships. Today, we are committed to ensuring that every product we come up with inter-operates well with all other products. That's the biggest change that has happened. If you look back two years, we had started seeing these changes coming into our main product. So, if you are a Java developer or a PHP developer, and want to develop on Windows, don't worry about it; we will provide you the tools required for developing on Windows and these tools are open source. That was the good starting point in India. That's where the partnership with the open source community began. We are learning to work with the open source community and the open source community is learning to work with us. If you look at mature markets like the US, there has been tremendous progress. We are in a mixed source environment today.

Q So, will it be correct to say that Microsoft's attitude has changed over six to seven years because customers have demanded it?

Look at it in this way—we've got to be very realistic on why we exist as an industry. It's not about Microsoft or open source companies. Individual developers exist for the purpose of serving the customers' need. So, for us, it is very natural to always do what customers need. That is reflected in every product that we have come up with and, obviously, there is a whole lot of innovation there. There are times when we have shown customers the right path, when we have seen them struggling in a certain area and have come up with solutions to help them. There have also been times when customers have come to us and said, "These are the changing business needs that I have, so now you go out and figure how you are going to help." So, I think that this change in Microsoft has occurred a long time ago. Six to seven years ago is when it has started to show, but the change actually began a long time ago and it was really driven by our customers.

Q Steve Balmer called Linux a cancer back in 2000, and the Linux Foundation recently released a report, which

shows that Microsoft is among the top 20 contributors to the kernel. Do you feel that Microsoft is still struggling with the image makeover?

What Steve Balmer said over 10 years ago is not denied, but it also reflected the reality of the software market at that time. It is just like, 10 years ago we couldn't have imagined that enterprises would be willing to give the up control of their on-premise software and put it on the cloud, because the options did not exist back then. It is also natural for the open source community and developers to ask this question. Today, I personally think there are no proprietary software developers or open source developers. A developer is a developer. Look, if we were really not keen and committed to work with the open source community or industry, there would have been no point for all these investments. We always knew that this journey to becoming more open as a company was not going to be a short one and hence we were always in it for the long haul. It has not been merely an image makeover, but a strategic shift in how we see ourselves working with others. If

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you look at the mature markets like North America or Europe, our partnership with the open source universe has really made a huge impact on enterprises and customers. As an example, let's look at our partnership with SUSE that we entered into a few years ago—there are customers who have deployed SUSE and Microsoft in a virtualised environment and this has happened because of the partnership. SUSE, too, was very keen on our partnership. So, honestly, it's not just lip service. It's not something fake to keep people quiet.

The IT industry is consistently and continuously changing, and we have to adapt to those changes. Our commitment of partnering with the open source community is a part of the journey. But that doesn't mean that we are not going to compete. We see competitors today even in the open source ecosystem, just like we see competitors in the proprietary ecosystem. This competition is separate from the overall development of the industry. So, when we speak about partnering with the open source ecosystem, we mean to work a way forward. When it comes to competing, we will keep on doing so with our open source competitors. So, if you talk